

STRATEGIC ADVICE: Day 5

Keywords:

Advanced Coalition Dynamics, Multi-Party-, Multi-Issue Negotiations

MULTI-PARTY NEGOTIATION STRATEGY:

To create value, build on differences. To create coalitions, build on similarities.

Before getting to the table

Identify the issues at stake, and their importance to you, and estimate how important each issue will be to the other parties. Anticipate likely coalitions/natural partners:

- Identify your own natural partners – those with whom you share many positions and interests.
- Identify the natural partners for each other party.

At the table

If building a blocking coalition, consider steps to disrupt the negotiation. For a winning coalition, take steps that foster cooperation and trust (remember: 3-Way Organization, Week 5), and consider the pros and cons of keeping everyone at the table versus meeting separately:

- **Consensus-driven** – staying at the table prevents the emergence of blocking coalitions.
- **Sidebars and caucuses** – separate meetings are safer and facilitate openness about interests, but can lead to cycling of coalitions.
- **Third-party agent** – interests could be represented by a “neutral” party.

Anticipate and influence the decision/voting rule (e.g., simple majority, 2/3rds rule, unanimity).

MULTIPARTY NEGOTIATION AND GROUP PROCESS*

- **Think carefully about the distribution rule to be used in allocating resources among the parties** (e.g., equity, equality, needs-based, historical precedent).
- **Avoid majority rule in group negotiations whenever possible.**
 - Majority rule is often used because it is easy and efficient, but it fails to recognize the strength of individual preferences.
 - Mixed-motive groups negotiating under a unanimous-decision rule reach more valuable outcomes than groups operating under majority rule because each party is required to make trade-offs that lead to an integrative outcome.